MA ENGLISH • SEMESTER 1

Block 4 — Unit 3: Dramatic Traditions from Kyd to Marlowe

CHAUCER TO THE ELIZABETHAN AGE

Expanded exam notes · Simple explanations + developed discussion

Based on the supplied SGOU self-learning material (M21EG01DC). These are study aids, not the original textbook. Everyday comparisons are teaching examples. The original notes and full textbook units remain available in the subject folder.

The chapter in one sentence

Kyd and Marlowe create tragedies in which people struggle against limits, try to choose their own futures, and suffer consequences that are both personal and social.

Start with a picture

Imagine a locked gate. One person tries to open it because justice is on the other side. Another wants to break through because he refuses any limit to his power. Hieronimo and Faustus face different gates, but both stories ask what happens when human desire meets a restrictive world.

1. Old dramatic traditions become new theatre

The Spanish Tragedy draws on revenge drama and Senecan influence. *Doctor Faustus* uses morality-play figures such as angels and devils. Both also develop psychologically intense central characters and powerful theatrical language.

This is a combination of inheritance and innovation. New drama did not appear by erasing everything that came before it.

2. Hieronimo: justice blocked by power

Hieronimo’s son is murdered. Although Hieronimo has an official judicial role, powerful enemies prevent him from obtaining justice. The contradiction is painful: a man connected with the law cannot make it protect his own family.

His revenge can therefore be read as a response to unequal institutions, not only as an individual outburst. Yet the revenge creates further deaths. Understanding the cause of an action does not remove its ethical difficulty.

3. Faustus: knowledge turns into domination

Faustus wants to exceed ordinary human limits. His aspirations express Renaissance excitement about human capacity. But he makes a destructive bargain and achieves much less than his grand promises suggest.

The tragedy lies in both punishment and wasted potential. The question is not simply “Was he clever?” but “What did he do with his ability, and why?”

4. Agency and determinism

Agency means the capacity to act and make choices. **Determinism** suggests that outcomes are governed or constrained by forces beyond individual control.

Hieronimo chooses revenge, yet injustice narrows his available routes. Faustus chooses the bargain, yet temptation, fear, despair, and the play’s theological world complicate his freedom.

A classroom analogy: someone may choose how to prepare for an exam, but resources, time, and rules affect the available choices. The analogy explains the distinction; it does not equate exams with the plays’ extreme suffering.

5. Inner conflict becomes visible

Faustus’s Good and Evil Angels can be read as stage representations of opposed impulses. They make an internal debate visible and audible.

In Kyd’s play, the ghost and Revenge watch and comment on events. This frame adds another level: human action is also placed within a larger pattern of destiny and retribution.

6. What kind of place is hell?

Mephistopheles describes hell through the loss of divine happiness, not only as a distant physical location. That idea connects external punishment with inward suffering. Faustus’s awareness of what he has rejected becomes part of the tragedy before the final scene.

7. Rethinking the tragic hero

These plays make tragic importance depend on suffering, desire, and potential as well as rank. Hieronimo’s grief matters even though he is not a king. Faustus’s intellectual capacity makes his loss powerful.

Hamartia is often translated as a tragic error or failing. It can help discussion, but do not reduce each play to one personality defect. Repeated decisions, social power, and religious or supernatural frameworks also shape the outcome.

Compare the plays

Question	Hieronimo	Faustus
Main desire	Justice for his murdered son	Knowledge and extraordinary power
Restricting force	Unequal political and legal power	Human limits and religious authority
Main action	Private revenge through theatre	A bargain with Lucifer
Tragic loss	Family, life, and the possibility of justice	Soul, life, and human potential

Build an exam answer

Use a comparative argument: both plays show agency under pressure, but the pressures differ. Explain the law in Kyd, theology and ambition in Marlowe, and the theatrical devices that make those conflicts visible. End by assessing why neither tragedy is merely a simple moral lesson.

Quick check

1. Why does Hieronimo’s public position matter? **It exposes the failure of institutions that should provide justice.**
2. What is agency? **The capacity to act and choose.**
3. Why is “Faustus was punished because he was bad” incomplete? **It ignores ambition, fear, wasted potential, and the play’s complex presentation of choice.**

Develop an exam answer

Practice question

Compare agency and constraint in the tragedies of Hieronimo and Faustus.

Expanded discussion

Hieronimo and Faustus become tragic figures through struggles that reveal both human capacity and its restrictions. Hieronimo wants justice after his son’s murder, but political privilege obstructs the institutions that should provide it. Faustus wants knowledge and power beyond ordinary human boundaries, but his attempt to escape limitation places him under a destructive contract. Their desires differ morally and socially, so comparison should establish parallels without making the characters identical.

Both plays adapt older theatrical traditions. Kyd uses the revenge framework, a ghost, and a personified Revenge; Marlowe uses the struggle for a soul, angels, and devils. These devices place individual actions within larger systems of meaning. At the same time, the protagonists’ suffering and self-division create an intensity that exceeds a simple demonstration of a moral rule. Audience sympathy can coexist with fear and judgement.

Agency remains central because the characters act rather than merely endure. Hieronimo constructs the performance through which he takes revenge, while Faustus repeatedly sustains or renews his chosen course. Nevertheless, social institutions, supernatural frameworks, and inward pressures make their freedom difficult to define. The final outcomes can appear both chosen and constrained, exposing the tension between self-determination and forces beyond the individual.

The sense of wasted possibility enlarges the tragic loss. Hieronimo's public identity cannot secure justice, and Faustus's intellectual promise collapses into trivial achievements and terror. Rather than explaining everything through a single flaw, a critical answer should examine repeated choices in relation to the worlds that shape them. These tragedies remain disturbing because human striving encounters a reality that offers no adequate protection against suffering.

Suggested answer structure

1. Different desires and shared struggle
2. Institutional power versus theological limits
3. Inherited devices and psychological depth
4. Chosen actions under constraint
5. Wasted potential and tragic significance

Common mistakes to avoid

Do not claim that revenge is the central action of Faustus merely because it is studied beside Kyd. Explain agency without pretending the characters have unlimited freedom.

Turn this into your own answer

Read the question again and choose only relevant sections. Make one clear point per paragraph, explain it, and connect it with a specific textual detail. Add accurate short quotations from the textbook where useful; the discussion above is paraphrase, not quoted text. Adjust length to the marks and time available.

Coverage review: extra exam details

Hamartia and the will to act

Hamartia can indicate an error or failing connected with tragic action; it should not automatically be translated into one permanent "fatal flaw." Hieronimo's deliberate planning and Faustus's repeated commitments invite discussion of willed action, not just a single accidental mistake. The unit places such action within larger restrictions of power, circumstance, and belief.

The supernatural frame in Kyd both permits revenge and complicates the idea of human control. In Marlowe, warnings and opposed voices make possibility visible while despair makes the future appear closed. The interpretation of freedom is therefore a question the plays dramatise, not a simple fact an answer should assume.

Blank verse gives intense individual aspirations a theatrical voice. Commercial performance, audience interest, and established stage conventions also shape the plays' effects. Compare

the protagonists' distinct desires and environments while explaining the shared tragic pressure: the human effort to assert significance encounters a world that does not guarantee a just or fulfilling outcome.

Textbook assignment checklist

These are the unit's assignment prompts, included as a revision checklist, not as predictions of the exam. Longer answers still need evidence from the assigned texts.

1. Detail the deployment of the trope of revenge in The Spanish Tragedy.
2. How does Doctor Faustus implicate the ambivalences of the Renaissance era?
3. Explore the ways in which The Spanish Tragedy and Doctor Faustus dramatise the plight of the individual within a world that is indifferent to human pain and striving.
4. Discuss Spanish Tragedy and Doctor Faustus with reference to Aristotle's hamartia.